STATUS REPORT

Eswatini — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-09-01 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Twenty of Eswatini's 22 assessed government ministries have no approved ICT strategy, a finding of the Digital Landscape Assessment Report the ICT ministry received and endorsed on 21 May 2026 and intends as the foundation of the next national e-Government Strategy.

At the centre the commitments are real and the machinery to deliver them is not. The Digitalisation Strategy 2024-2028, branded 'Government in Your Hand', is in place and counts data exchange and interoperability among its aims, but the coordinating machinery behind the strategy is only planned or in draft, and delivery runs ministry by ministry rather than as one government (2025). A Digital Government Implementation Roadmap is still under development under the World Bank-financed Digital Eswatini project, with terms of reference published for a consultant and nothing finalised (2025).

Sector strategy is thicker than central strategy. The Central Bank and the Ministry of Finance launched a National FinTech Strategy 2025-2030 in December 2025, aiming to cut reliance on cash and position the country as a regional fintech hub, alongside a National Financial Inclusion Strategy 2023-2028. Hosting has no policy of its own, the National Cybersecurity Strategy 2022-2027 standing in for a government cloud policy while also covering data protection, identification, payments and signatures.

Data governance has been the year's business, on a body that sits inside another institution with no data strategy behind it. The national data policy was still at procurement in July 2025, tendered by Smart Africa on a US$70,000 budget; a first National Data Policy Workshop followed in April 2026, where the ICT minister framed data as an asset to be managed like land, water and financial reserves; and the National Data Governance Policy was validated by stakeholders on 27 July 2026, with an implementation cycle of 2027-2031. Its text is not published, no adoption date has been given and no implementing body is named. Whether it will be backed by a standalone law or by amendments to existing legislation was still undecided in August 2026.

Legislation and regulation

Eswatini's statute book gives no arm of government the authority to share data with another: neither the Data Protection Act 2022 nor the Electronic Communications and Transactions Act 2022 establishes a basis for cross-government data sharing or governs a data exchange system, and the legislative basis for interoperability has still to be created (2025).

Much of what is on the books was written for something else and stretched to cover the rest. The Computer Crime and Cybercrime Act 2022 is the cybercrime statute and also carries the country's provisions on digital signatures, electronic commerce and digital payments; the Electronic Communications Act governs quality of service and universal access while reaching into identification, payments and signatures. Legal identity still rests on the Identification Order, 1998, which makes a national identity document compulsory from the age of 16 and makes it the codified proof of identity used for banking checks and SIM registration, and there is no regulation specific to digital identity of any kind (2024). Payment service providers are licensed under the National Payment Systems Act 2023.

The 2022 burst was fast: all four of that year's ICT Acts were tabled with certificates of urgency, shortening the time available for stakeholder and public input. What has followed is slower. The government said in August 2025 that bills on cybersecurity, critical infrastructure, e-commerce and the governance of artificial intelligence, robotics and satellite activity were in preparation, and no right to information law is in force, a bill remaining in draft (2025). What the ministry has to show for 2026 is not a statute at all: it told Parliament in August that it had completed Online Media Publishing Guidelines requiring online publishers to register, binding them to accuracy, corrections, privacy, safeguards for children and the responsible use of AI in publishing.

Data protection

The data protection authority's first major enforcement action is against a government ministry: ESCCOM opened an investigation into the Ministry of Home Affairs in June 2026 over the exposure of citizens' ID documents, after it published unblurred national identity documents on X.

The Data Protection Act 2022 has been in force since 4 March 2022 as a general-purpose law binding public and private sectors alike, treating biometric data — fingerprinting, DNA analysis, retinal scanning and voice recognition — as sensitive personal information, and it reaches businesses outside the country that target its residents. It provides for fines of up to E5,000,000 or 2% of annual turnover, requires notification of a breach to the authority and to affected people within 72 hours, and imposes no data localisation requirement.

The same body regulates the communications sector and polices data protection, with no separate data-protection institution. Its work is real but recent. The World Bank recorded in mid-2025 that the data protection office had still not been operationalised; by February 2026 the authority was setting out eight data-subject rights in a public campaign, and in July 2026 it said it had concluded a complaint over a health practitioner's unlawful disclosure of a patient's information. It maintains a mandatory register of controllers and processors, operates a cross-border transfer authorisation process, and has issued enforcement notices against MTN Eswatini, Liberty Life Swaziland, the Royal Science and Technology Park and the Sincephetelo Motor Vehicle Fund (2024). The ICT ministry stated in August 2026 that enforcement and oversight of compliance fall outside its mandate.

Two limits sit around it. The Association for Progressive Communications reads section 36 as supplying grounds for the authority to take no action on complaints filed with it (2024), and payment data has no cover of its own, the Act applying to payment service providers as a general law with nothing specific to payment transaction data. It operates in a narrowing rights environment: Eswatini's Digital Freedom score fell 15.5 points over 2014-2023 to 39.9 out of 100, ranking 38th of 54 African states, the sharpest decline of any measure in that index's rights sub-category.

Regional collaboration

Eswatini's payment rails stop at the border. The national switch carries domestic payments only, with interlinking to SADC's Transactions Cleared on an Immediate Basis scheme identified as a priority and no live retail cross-border corridor, while high-value settlement continues to run over SADC-RTGS. The national identity document is not yet interoperable for cross-border recognition either, though the country takes part in the SADC initiative working towards a regional digital identity framework (2025).

Personal data crosses more easily than money does. Transfers to other SADC member states run under regional data protection standards while anything beyond the bloc turns on an adequacy assessment — a regional-bloc adequacy model rather than a purely national one.

Much of the country's own rulebook for that data is being written through continental and European channels. Smart Africa tendered the national data policy and a five-year roadmap component with it (2025), Smart Africa also developed the draft health-data guidelines and sponsors their validation workshops, with technical and financial support from GIZ, and support for the National Data Governance Policy runs through the Team Europe Data Governance in Africa Initiative with GIZ and the African Union.

Bilateral reach is mostly prospective. Talks with the Central Bank of Egypt in July 2026 covered accelerating Eswatini's accession to the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System, and the pan-African gold bank raised in them rests on a memorandum of understanding signed between the Central Bank of Egypt and Afreximbank on 29 December 2025 that remains at feasibility-study stage. Where the country has moved early is civil registration: it was the second African state to launch phase two of the UN Economic Commission for Africa's registration and vital statistics mentorship programme, work that includes linking birth and death registration to the national population register (2024).

Standards

Eswatini has no government open source policy and no recorded adoption of open source software anywhere in the public sector (2025), and open source is not a route by which local firms supply government.

Where standards do bite it is through procurement and through the payment system. Electronic government procurement is under implementation, publishes both tender notices and awarded contracts, and is used to enforce technical standards on suppliers (2025). The Central Bank publishes the full rulebook of the national payment systems — clearing and settlement rules, minimum standards for electronic payments, the fast payments directive, the oversight framework and the practice note for mobile money providers — freely and without registration. Against that, the same index that records service-level standards and a programme to retire legacy systems onto a common standard records no data quality standard governing exchange between government systems.

The first sectoral standard under the data protection regime is now in the making. The authority began validating draft advisory guidelines on the lawful processing of personal health data in week-long workshops at Ezulwini from 28 July 2026, bringing in the Ministry of Health, public and private providers, insurers, pharmacies and medical aid schemes, and intends them to issue as a regulatory instrument under the Data Protection Act 2022 covering collection, retention, sharing, breach notification, cloud services, impact assessments and patient rights. The Act itself sets the baseline every controller must already meet: a prohibition on processing sensitive data without explicit authorisation, notification of breaches, and a mandatory data protection officer.

Service standards in communications are enforceable but quickly time-barred. The Electronic Communications Act requires licensed operators to run complaint-handling mechanisms and the Eswatini Communications Commission Act 2013 lets the regulator investigate and determine consumer complaints against licensees free of charge, but the window to bring one is a month for postal and courier services, three months for broadcasting and six months for telecommunications.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The public has no online route into Eswatini's policymaking and none by which to complain about a government service: there is no e-participation or public consultation platform and no citizen feedback or grievance mechanism (2025).

Deliberation is no stronger away from the web. Eswatini's Deliberative and Participatory Governance score fell 3.9 points over 2014-2023 to 23.7 out of 100, ranking 47th of 54 African states — among the continent's weakest positions on whether policy is consulted on before it is made. The legislative record bears it out: all four of the 2022 ICT Acts were tabled with certificates of urgency, shortening the time for public input.

Argument needs records, and records are the harder half. No right to information law is in force, with a bill in draft (2025); the state publishes more of its records than most of the continent while being among the worst in Africa at letting anyone obtain one on request.

Expression has moved in two directions. Media Freedom rose 9.3 points over 2014-2023 to 43.6 out of 100, though the country still ranks 40th of 54; over the same decade Freedom of Expression and Belief fell 18.2 points to 36.2, ranking 43rd, and public perception of freedom of speech sits at the index's floor score. The state has reached for the network itself before: during the 2021 upheaval it directed EPTC, MTN Eswatini and Eswatini Mobile to suspend internet services, and social media was restricted again that October.

The next constraint on that space is being drafted now. The ICT ministry's Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026 would require online publishers to register, on a motivation the ministry gives as competitive rather than technological: mainstream outlets carry permit and licensing costs and formal oversight while online platforms compete for the same audience and advertising without them. Where argument has broken through it has done so outside official channels — parents and teachers refused a school biometric gate-pass scheme over consent and child-data privacy in July 2025, and a senator told the Senate in August 2026 that data governance is where the country is most exposed.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The one standing agreement with a named technology vendor is a memorandum of understanding with Google, and in April 2026 it became a cabinet dispute: Prime Minister Russell Dlamini first dismissed it, saying Google was unaware of it and calling it a national-security threat, then acknowledged in writing that Cabinet had approved it, after the Attorney-General confirmed that Minister Savannah Maziya had consulted both Cabinet and the Attorney-General before signing.

The partnership was announced on or before 20 January 2025 and covers Google Workspace for public servants, artificial intelligence, digital addressing and youth digital skills. An investigation of the April 2026 row concluded that it is a framework for cloud services and e-government rather than a monetisation or revenue-sharing arrangement, and treated the public controversy as a failure of communication.

Elsewhere the meetings have outrun the signatures. At the February 2026 meeting with Global South Utilities on powering the National Data Centre no agreement was signed, and no capacity, price or timetable was stated. The pan-African gold bank raised with Eswatini's central bank rests on a memorandum of understanding signed on 29 December 2025 between the Central Bank of Egypt and Afreximbank, scoped around an accredited refinery, secure vaulting and trading services in a designated Egyptian free zone; it is at feasibility-study stage and Eswatini is not a party to it.

New investments

Eswatini's largest live external commitment is the World Bank's Digital Eswatini Project, active over 2026–2031 with a digital-sector commitment of about US$20 million, covering broadband deployment, government service platforms and the enabling environment for the digital economy. The Ministry of ICT was training cross-ministry change agents ahead of a 2027 rollout of the E1.2bn (about US$65m) programme in June 2026. The Bank's own concept paper of June 2025 printed the operation at US$65.16m proposed, with appraisal and Board approval both given as estimated dates.

The earlier money is smaller, and mostly either spent or still waiting to move. About US$5 million for the Eswatini IFMIS and PFM Capacity Building Project rolled the Integrated Financial Management Information System out to line ministries between 2020 and 2023, and is closed. A World Bank health-system project appraised in May 2020 finances the electronic Community-Based Health Information System among its components, and stands at approval rather than disbursement. India's Export-Import Bank signed a line of credit of about US$10 million to build a disaster recovery site for the national data centre under Phase 2 of the Royal Science and Technology Park in 2021 — an agreement to lend, with no completed site behind it.

Two other World Bank operations touch the estate without being digital projects: the extension of the Imbeleko social registry beyond its pilot region (2025) and expanded rural electrification reaching 200,000 people (February 2025).

Four external commitments to the digital estate are on record, spanning windows from 2020 to 2031 and together worth roughly US$55 million (August 2026).

Two financiers account for all of it: the World Bank on three of the four commitments and the large majority of the money, and India's Export-Import Bank, the only bilateral lender on record, on the rest (August 2026).

The four sit one apiece in different parts of the estate — broadband connectivity, data-centre disaster recovery, public financial management and health information systems — so no part of it has drawn a second external commitment (August 2026).

All of the money is lending on concessional terms rather than grant or equity finance (August 2026).

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Fifteen of Eswatini's 22 assessed government ministries were running on internet connections of 1 Mbps or less (May 2026), in the same year the state put E1.2 billion behind a Digital Eswatini programme to connect schools, clinics and communities. The money splits roughly E648 million for broadband and E450 million for the government services platform (June 2026), with Ministry of ICT change agents trained through mid-2026 to roll it out, and the World Bank's Digital Eswatini Project is the largest single active digital commitment recorded for the country. A nationwide fibre rollout is under way and international capacity has risen past the target set for it (February 2026).

Reach runs well ahead of use. LTE and WiMAX covered 87% of the population (2024), while 57.6% of individuals used the internet (2025), and the exclusion is concentrated among rural people, the elderly and people with disabilities. Mobile connections exceed the whole population on both the regulator's and GSMA's counts, but those are SIMs rather than people, and no unique-subscriber figure has been published (2025). Price is part of the gap: the cheapest 2GB mobile plan costs about 3.4% of monthly GNI per capita, above the UN Broadband Commission's 2% target, with fixed broadband around 19% (2025).

The country still has no active internet exchange point (2024), so domestic traffic is handed off abroad; there is no in-country hyperscale cloud region either, though zones in the same sub-region sit 6-10ms away (2025). The National Data Centre is carrier-neutral on two diverse provider feeds. Government commissioned a Starlink gateway in April 2026, following a Starlink Business reseller launched locally in July 2025.

The sector runs under the Electronic Communications Act, with SIM registration mandatory against a national ID or passport, and in 2021 the government directed operators to suspend internet services during the June–July upheaval. On the Ibrahim Index, mobile communications was Eswatini's second most improved of 96 indicators over 2014-2023, reaching 65.2 out of 100, while internet and computers reached only 43.9 and public perception of infrastructure fell to 49.1 (2023).

Data Storage

Eswatini's government systems depend near-universally on the Royal Science and Technology Park for hosting, maintenance and system development, which the state's own Digital Landscape Assessment names a "structural concentration risk" because ministries have no internal fallback if that capacity is delayed or disrupted (May 2026).

The facility at the centre of it is the National Data Centre, operated by the Park as the country's basic government data centre (2025). It is carrier-neutral on two diverse provider feeds, backed by four 500 KVA diesel generators, with biometric access into smart rows of 42U racks, and it sells colocation and remote hands alongside platform, infrastructure and software as a service. Its only public description discloses no capacity in racks or megawatts, no named tenant, no uptime-tier certification and no utilisation figure (July 2026). The second site that would carry it has not arrived. The 2021 budget speech recorded construction begun on a Disaster Recovery Site at KaLanga in the Lubombo region, with E58 million allocated, financed by a US$10.4 million India Exim Bank line of credit signed that year for the Park's second phase; four years later the communications regulator was advertising a tender for consultancy services on a data centre disaster recovery facility (October 2025), and nothing on this record shows the KaLanga site operating. The wider estate is small-scale Tier I-II facilities only (2024), and with no hyperscale region in the country, the nearest availability zones are across the border at 6-10ms (2025).

What sits on that estate is thinly protected. Nine of the roughly 22 ministries assessed keep no regular backups at all, seven back up daily, three weekly and three monthly, eleven hold no ICT maintenance contract, and the Ministry of Finance runs end-of-life IBM mainframe software, with water, mining, energy and social-grant data flagged at risk of unrecoverable loss (May 2026).

Nothing binds that data to the country: the Data Protection Act imposes no localisation requirement, permitting cross-border transfer within SADC and beyond it subject to an adequacy assessment. Nor is there a dedicated government cloud policy — the National Cybersecurity Strategy 2022-2027 stands in for one, covering data centres and cloud services alongside data protection, digital identification, payments and signatures.

Energy

Nearly three in five Eswatini firms reported electrical outages, at around 1.2 a month (2024) — the reliability side of an access record that is otherwise strong for the region. About 88% of the population had electricity (2025), and access to energy scored 65.5 out of 100 in 2023, twelfth of 54 African states and up 11.2 points over the decade.

The remaining gap is rural. Urban access stood at 92.2% against 75.8% in rural areas in 2020, a difference of 16.4 percentage points. An off-grid and rural electrification policy is active, with World Bank support expanded in February 2025 for a programme reaching 200,000 people. Tariffs are set by the Eswatini Energy Regulatory Authority, which holds a subsidised lifeline block for the first 75 kWh of monthly consumption at about E1.40-E1.69 per kWh alongside cost-reflective average tariffs of roughly E2.47-E3.14 per kWh across 2024/25 to 2026/27 (2025).

Most generation is domestic hydro and bagasse, with thermal power imported from South Africa that domestic generation statistics do not count (2024). Dedicated supply for the National Data Centre is still unsettled: the ICT minister met an Abu Dhabi clean-energy firm at the World Government Summit in Dubai to discuss reliable and sustainable power for the facility, and no agreement, capacity, price or timetable came out of the meeting (February 2026).

Technical Capacity

Eighteen ICT professionals support the whole of Eswatini's assessed government estate, and 15 of its ministries have none in-house at all (May 2026). Eleven hold no formal ICT maintenance contract either, and the state's own assessment finds ministries leaning on the Royal Science and Technology Park not only for hosting but for maintenance and system development, with nothing internal to fall back on.

The tertiary pipeline is narrow and easily named: computer science, information technology and computer science education degrees at the University of Eswatini, with master's and postgraduate diploma provision, alongside ICT at the Eswatini College of Technology (2024). Government's own measured e-government readiness rose sharply in 2024, while the civil service underneath it scored in the bottom quarter of African states on effective administration that year and had gone backwards over the decade. The data protection office still awaited full operationalisation (2025).

Against that base, the declared ambition is to build rather than buy: Eswatini's stated position is that small and developing nations should not become mere consumers of technologies developed elsewhere and should invest in local innovation, research, computing infrastructure and data people can trust (July 2026).

Cybersecurity

Eswatini scores 79.43 on the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, in the index's advancing tier — a reading of instruments in place that the state's own look at its estate does not bear out. An assessment found critical state information at risk in nine ministries, with the back-end interoperability framework still lacking across most of government (2025).

The detail is worse than the headline. Nine of the roughly 22 ministries assessed keep no regular data backups and only seven back up daily (May 2026), the Ministry of Finance runs mainframe software past end-of-life and without vendor support, and the near-universal dependence on one hosting provider leaves ministries with nowhere to fail over.

Policy and law are further along than practice. The National Cybersecurity Strategy 2022-2027 covers cybersecurity, data centres and cloud services, data protection, digital identification, payments and signatures, and the Computer Crime and Cybercrime Act 2022 is the binding statute. Dedicated cybersecurity and critical-infrastructure legislation was announced as in preparation and not yet enacted (August 2025), so no critical information infrastructure regime is in force. Breach notification is mandatory under the data protection regime. A digital forensic unit works on cybercrime investigation (2025), and the Prime Minister opened a Cybersecurity Awareness Month in October 2025 under a "Secure Eswatini" banner, framing cyber security as national, economic and personal security.

The flagship government platform was security-tested in public rather than in audit: six weeks after GIYH launched, a reporter located other people's data on it and the eGovernment services director conceded the gaps, pointing to the need for a proper digital ID and digital signatures (July 2025). The regulator has separately urged broadcasters to handle artificial intelligence ethically, warning that deepfakes erode public trust (November 2025).

DPI

Data Exchange

The one substantial data link running inside Eswatini's government sits in the health sector, where the Population Registry feeds the health service's Master Patient Index over FHIR for real-time patient identification (2026). Nothing comparable joins the rest of the state: agriculture, the electoral register, employment and labour market data, driver licensing, passports and immigration, education records, justice and case management, health and payments all sit outside any cross-government exchange, because no such platform exists (2025).

The 2024 Digital Readiness Assessment named the absence of a national Interoperability Framework a major obstacle to digital transformation, raising operating costs through duplicated processes and limiting data sharing across systems. More than half of the ministries assessed lack meaningful interoperability or connectivity to a central repository (May 2026), and statistical, census and administrative data are not available for cross-government use in planning. What exists is centralised: no sub-national government participates in any data exchange platform, and no public dashboard reports on exchange operations (2024).

The legal footing has still to be laid. Neither the Data Protection Act 2022 nor the Electronic Communications and Transactions Act 2022 establishes authority for cross-government data sharing or governs an exchange system. Where one agency needs another's data it arranges the matching itself: the Revenue Service's 2025 Digital Transformation Agenda checks tax records against data held on properties, trusts, commerce and vehicle registrations to verify declarations.

The World Bank-financed Digital Eswatini project, approved in 2025, is designed to build the back-end interoperability framework alongside a digital identity and a digitalised National Population Register, and the terms of reference for the Government in Your Hand roadmap scope the intended platform across digital identity, data exchange, social registries, public key infrastructure and payments (2025).

Digital Identity and CRVS

Production of national identity cards was suspended in late September 2025 and resumed only on 22 February 2026; the five-month halt disrupted access to banking, employment and travel at service centres nationwide. The card, issued in physical form since 2003, is not a digital credential: no biometrics, and no way to authenticate a holder directly or through a government portal (2024). No national digital identity scheme is in deployment, and there is no digital-ID regulation, no identity act codifying such a credential and no procedural rules for identity data management. The state's flagship app accordingly authenticates users by national ID number and an SMS one-time password.

Possession is compulsory from the age of 16 under the Identification Order 1998, which establishes the National Population Register and makes the card the codified proof of identity for banking checks and SIM registration. First enrolment is free within three months of turning 16, then costs E100 up to age 25 and E250 from 26, with replacement at E300 (fee schedule effective March 2021). An estimated 88% of people aged 15 and over held a government-issued identity document in 2021-2022, above the 78% sub-Saharan African average, yet public perception of how easily one can be obtained fell 26.5 points to 38.0 out of 100 in 2023.

The card is what opens the state: banks take it as the primary know-your-customer document (2025), a national ID or passport is required to register a SIM card, and the Social Welfare Department will not pay the Elderly Grant without one (2025). Refugees and non-citizens holding valid status are eligible for a 'non-Swazi' document (2022). Civil registration sits in the same ministry, which assigns a Personal Identification Number on registration of a vital event (2024), though registration is far from complete. Identity data governance rests entirely on the general Data Protection Act 2022, with no identity-specific sharing framework and no portal through which a person can view their own record. About US$11.5 million of the Digital Eswatini project is allocated to the digital public infrastructure that includes digital ID, with no comparable domestic allocation (2026).

Digital Payments and Fintech

More than 90% of person-to-business payments were still cash-based in 2025, the year after the national instant-payments rail went live. The Eswatini Payment Switch's Fast Payments module launched on 11 December 2024, built by Paylogic, and carries real-time transfers up to E50,000 across banks and non-banks, including account-to-wallet and wallet-to-wallet; single wallet transactions are capped at E10,000. It connects the four commercial banks, the Swaziland Building Society and three mobile-money operators, and participation is mandated for every payment service provider offering local payment services. Fast payments are the first of three stages, ahead of open banking and then card, POS and ATM switching, and the Central Bank built beyond banks because the existing infrastructure had been built for banks and banks do not reach most people.

The Bank finances and operates the switch itself and reported 98.6% reliability against a 98% uptime target in 2024/25. Mobile money is what has driven account growth (August 2025). The switch is domestic only, with no live retail cross-border instant corridor and high-value settlement still over SADC-RTGS (2025).

Government collects digitally more readily than it pays. The Revenue Service takes tax and customs payments by electronic transfer, mobile money, card and bank deposit, has handled no cash at its own offices since April 2021, cash falling from 36% of tax transactions in 2018 to 2% in 2021, and 35 post offices now act as payment points for government services (September 2025). Payments out are only lightly digitised, against a target of digitising 80% of recurring government payments by 2028.

Licensing runs under the National Payment Systems Act 2023, and the Practice Note for Mobile Money Service Providers requires fee disclosure, written customer agreements, working complaints and dispute resolution, free hotlines and confidentiality, published in full and without registration. Scheme governance runs through a National Payments Council with no reserved seats for consumers or small providers (2023). Access points make no accommodation for persons with disabilities, and refugees reach digital accounts only partially, on refugee and non-Swazi documents accepted by several banks and by MTN's mobile money under simplified due diligence (2025).

Registries

Eswatini's most complete population-scale register is the electoral roll — 584,710 voters registered for the September 2023 general elections, about 91.2% of the eligible electorate on 2018 census figures — and it is joined to nothing: the Elections and Boundaries Commission runs it on its own biometric system, separate from the national identity and population registers and outside any government-wide exchange (2023).

Civil registration covers live births, deaths, marriages and divorces and is only partly digitised, with manual certificates still being converted under a Modernization of Civil Registration and Immigration Systems project (2024). At rural offices details are captured on paper and later keyed into the National Population Register over networked terminals (2024). Completeness is rising from a low base: 61% of births and 62% of deaths were registered in 2025, against 8.3% and 26.5% in 2016, on figures announced at the ninth Africa civil registration day, and 35.6% of births and 55% of deaths in 2022 on the last annual report held in full. Against that, civil registration scored 50.0 out of 100 in 2023, 31st of 54 African states, unmoved across the decade to 2023. A Civil Registration and Vital Statistics Strategic Plan 2022-2027 and a 'closing of the tap' initiative link birth registration directly to entries in the population register.

The Deeds Registry covers only Title Deed Land, about 25% of the country; the remaining 75%, Swazi Nation Land, is held under customary tenure through Chiefs and is not formally registered (2019), and deeds are still registered and stored manually, with an electronic Deeds Registration Information System in prospect (2025), though government's own report to Parliament a year earlier had put a phase-2 prototype of that system at 60% completion and under testing for gradual rollout (October 2024). The Surveyor General holds nationwide cadastral maps on a GIS platform, unlinked to the Deeds Registry in any single land information system. There is no national address register. The standard for one arrived in July 2026: the Eswatini National Addressing Standards, the ISO 19160 parts 1 and 2 domesticated as SZNS, were launched by the standards authority with the communications regulator and the ICT and housing ministries, and Mbabane is leading implementation of a national street addressing and house numbering programme as one of two pilot municipalities. What exists is a standard and two pilots, six weeks old.

90.3% of firms were formally registered with the Registrar of Companies when they began operations (2024), and applicants for a Tax Identification Number present a certified copy of their national identity document (2024). The Imbeleko social registry has completed a pilot in Shiselweni registering 44,683 of an estimated 47,766 households (2026) and began a second regional rollout in Lubombo in August 2026 on an E41.7 million data-collection exercise, two of four regions in two years; US$2.5 million from the World Bank is to extend it beyond the pilot (2025), and targeting relies on a proxy means test derived from household survey data.

Sectoral management information systems

The Ministry of Finance runs IBM mainframe software that is past end-of-life and carries no vendor support (May 2026). Health is the furthest ahead: the Client Management Information System, an electronic medical record live in 73% of public health facilities, uses a unique identity number to link patient records and prevent duplicate registrations (2026), and community-level data collected by Rural Health Motivators is being moved onto a separate electronic Community-Based Health Information System (February 2026). Education runs a DHIS2-based management information system nationwide after a Manzini pilot, though unreliable internet, a shortage of school-owned devices and limited digital skills leave most rural primary schools collecting enrolment, attendance and learner data on paper for later entry (2024); a learner-record mobile application launched in March 2024 had reached around 60 schools by October 2024.

Revenue is the most digitised and most self-contained. Online filing is mandatory for all income taxpayers through the Revenue Service's e-Tax system (2024), and real-time fiscalisation of VAT data from retail transactions is being introduced against an E4.4 billion tax gap (2025). But only the customs system exchanges data with other government systems; the tax administration system stands alone (2025).

The integrated financial management information system is still under implementation, built on custom software, covering central government only and spanning treasury and budget preparation; a treasury single account is under implementation and only partially used by ministries, departments and agencies (2025); and a public debt management system is in use, with no public investment management system. Budgetary and financial management scored 47.2 out of 100 in 2023, up 11.1 points over the decade — the largest gain of any public administration measure.

The public-service human resource system runs on custom software and uses the national identification number as its identifier, with payroll on a hybrid of custom and off-the-shelf software (2025). The social insurance and pension system is run as a separate scheme for public employees rather than as a single national system. An Integrated Electronic Case Management System linking the police, the judiciary, the Law Society and the Anti-Corruption Commission was launched in August 2025.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Only 31 of Eswatini's 419 government services were available online in May 2026, a year after the state's flagship citizen app went live. Government in Your Hand launched at Ezulwini on 21 May 2025, letting users track identity, passport and travel-document status, register businesses and reach education-loan information, with vehicle licences payable in the app by mobile money (2025). The roadmap procured behind it scopes the platform at roughly 200 government services (2025).

There is no national service portal — no single online front door, no transactional services delivered through one, and no company formation available that way (2025), while the sectoral portals work: an online tax portal covering registration, filing and payment, an online social protection portal covering benefit administration and payments, and a state employment portal covering jobseeker registration and vacancy search are each in use and reaching ordinary users. Company registration has run through the trade portal since 2020, though full incorporation still involves manual steps at the Registrar of Companies, and a Business One-Stop Shop opened on 21 July 2025, joining business registration, Tax Identification Number applications and work-permit processing in one facility. Electronic government procurement is under implementation rather than complete, publishing both tender notices and awarded contracts and used to enforce technical standards on suppliers (2025).

Eswatini scored 0.6081 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, 113th of 193 countries, up from 141st and 0.4498 in 2022. An institution coordinating digital transformation is established, with both coordination and audit functions, but the machinery to deliver the national digital transformation strategy is only planned or in draft, and delivery runs ministry by ministry rather than as one government, borne out by the near-absence of approved ICT strategies across ministries (May 2026). Little of how the digital estate is run is published (2025), and there is no e-participation platform and no citizen feedback or grievance mechanism.

Of the 32 headline indicators assessed for Eswatini in the 2025 GovTech Maturity Index update, 19 record a system, institution or law in place, five record something under implementation or in draft, and eight record the item as absent.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Eswatini's digital government services are centralised at national level, with no sub-national government taking part in any data exchange platform and no public dashboard reporting on data exchange operations (2024). The financial plumbing stops at the same line: the integrated financial management information system is still under implementation and covers central government only, spanning treasury and budget preparation (2025). Where the state has extended its reach below the centre it has done so through existing counters rather than through local government systems, with post offices opened as payment points for government services to cut the distance citizens travel to pay (September 2025), and with the Tinkhundla structures used as the channel for engaging communities on the digitisation rollout (June 2026). Connectivity constrains the centre as well: most of the assessed government ministries run on internet connections of 1 Mbps or less (May 2026). The visible local-level programme is in the capital, where Mbabane is being fitted out as a smart city with 5G and public Wi-Fi (August 2025).

Rural digital data capture

Eswatini's education ministry runs a DHIS2-based management information system nationwide, yet most rural primary schools still collect enrolment, attendance and learner data on paper for later manual entry, held back by unreliable internet, a shortage of school-owned devices and limited digital skills (2024). Rural civil registry offices, among them Hlathikhulu, Hluti and Nhlangano, work a hybrid: informants present a chief's or indvuna's letter, officers complete the paper birth and death forms by hand, and the details are then keyed into the National Population Register over networked terminals (2024). Health is where capture has moved furthest: the government-owned electronic medical record supports entry at the point of care, and the community-level data gathered by Rural Health Motivators is being taken off paper into a separate electronic community health information system (February 2026).

The conditions for capture are thinner than the systems assume. Rural households were markedly less likely to have electricity than urban ones (2020), and the World Bank expanded its support for rural electrification in February 2025; digital exclusion remains concentrated among rural populations, the elderly and people with disabilities (2024). The national digitisation programme is meant to connect schools, clinics and communities to the internet, and reaches rural populations through the Tinkhundla local-government structures, which are being used to engage communities on the rollout (June 2026).

What there is to capture is itself partly unrecorded. Land held under customary tenure through Chiefs, the bulk of the country, sits outside the formal Deeds Registry, and no national address register has been deployed, leaving homesteads, clinics and schools without a standardised address (2024). Farm information and livestock tools reached farmers through a new operator platform in June 2026, and mobile money reaches rural areas the banks do not. Against that, Eswatini's Rural Economy score fell 19.6 points over 2014-2023 to 50.4 out of 100, ranking 36th of 54 African states, by a wide margin the largest decline of any of the index's sixteen sub-categories and the leading driver of the country's overall governance deterioration (2023).

Technology

AI

The one artificial-intelligence system running in production in Eswatini's government sits inside a single revenue agency: the Eswatini Revenue Service's TaxCore fiscalisation platform applies machine learning to real-time tax fraud detection and predictive analytics over daily business transactions (2025), stand-alone and outside any inter-agency data exchange. Nothing equivalent has reached the public: the index that surveys citizen-facing government services records no use of AI or chatbots in them (2025). The visible AI deployment beyond tax is in the street rather than the service — AI-enabled cameras form part of the smart-city fit-out of the capital, Mbabane (August 2025).

Regulation has arrived sideways. The communications regulator ESCCOM urged broadcasters in November 2025 to manage AI ethically and transparently, warning that misinformation and deepfakes erode public trust, guidance to licensees rather than an enforceable rule. The ICT ministry then said in August 2026 that it had completed Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026, whose registration requirement for online publishers carries provisions on the responsible use of AI in publishing. Governance of AI and robotics also sits among the areas of legislation announced as in preparation and not yet enacted (August 2025).

Two Eswatini instruments now reach artificial intelligence without being AI instruments: the broadcasting guidance of November 2025 and the online media guidelines of 2026.

The national position is declaratory and outward-facing. Speaking for King Mswati III at the Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva, the Prime Minister called for a human-centred approach on the principle that technology must serve people (July 2026), and argued that small and developing nations should not become mere consumers of technologies developed elsewhere, but invest in local innovation, research, digital literacy, computing infrastructure and trusted data ecosystems. That posture is anchored in a National 4IR Strategy covering coding, data science and AI education rather than in an AI strategy of its own — one was announced two years ago and has not appeared. At the country's first AI indaba in November 2024 the ICT ministry said it would develop a National AI Strategy and a 4IR Strategy in that financial year, and what reached stakeholder validation in February 2026 was a review of the science, technology and innovation policy together with a combined 4IR and 5IR strategy, neither of them an AI strategy and neither yet published, and the skills base behind it rests on the ICT ministry's national digital-skills target (February 2026), pursued with the Eswatini Innovators Association, the Royal Science and Technology Park and UNDP.

ICT Industry

Forming a company in Eswatini happens over a counter rather than online. The Business One-Stop Shop, opened by the Eswatini Investment Promotion Authority on 21 July 2025, brings business and trading-licence registration together with tax identification number applications through the Revenue Service and work-permit processing through Home Affairs inside a single facility — while there is no single online front door to government services, and no company formation or business registration available that way (2025). Formality itself is not the barrier: 90.3% of firms were registered with the Registrar of Companies when they began operations, above 89% across most firm sizes and sectors (2024).

The commercial hosting a domestic sector would build on exists in one place, the National Data Centre, which sells platform, infrastructure and software as a service alongside colocation and remote hands. What runs on it competes with the power supply: 58.5% of firms experience electrical outages, at around 1.2 a month (2024).

Innovation ecosystem

Eswatini does not appear in the international measures of innovation or of the money behind it. It is not among the 133 economies covered by the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024, and so carries no rank or score in that edition, and it registers no visible venture capital activity in Partech's 2025 Africa tech venture capital report.

What does exist is buildings and programmes. The Royal Science and Technology Park Business Incubator is the country's AfriLabs-affiliated technology hub (2025); a government- and UNDP-backed iHub opened in Piggs Peak in 2025, with further hubs planned across all four regions; and MTN Eswatini and the ICT ministry launched a Content Creator Hub in June 2026 offering skills and opportunities to the creative economy.

The state side is recorded as present but unnamed. A startup and innovation framework with state startup financing is in place, and public-private partnership arrangements exist for delivering government services online, while no state programme supports small and medium enterprises in the digital sector (2025); the same index records a public-sector innovation strategy, a programme and an established institution running it, covering digital skills and public-service innovation (2025). One route in is closed: there is no government open source software policy and no recorded adoption of open source in the public sector, so it is not a way for local firms to supply government.

Capacity

Literacy

Eswatini's education is becoming less evenly distributed: its Equality in Education score fell 7.6 points over the decade to 2023, to 37.1 out of 100, ranking 42nd of 54 African states — the weakest of the five education indicators measured for the country. It sits against an enrolment record that is among the continent's strongest, 77.3 out of 100 for Education Enrolment in 2023, third in Africa and up 2.8 points over the same decade. Getting children into a classroom is the thing the country does well; spreading the benefit of it evenly across regions and groups is what has slipped.

The classrooms themselves are not where digital familiarity is being picked up. The Ministry of Education and Training's education management information system runs nationwide on DHIS2, yet most rural primary schools still record enrolment and attendance on paper for later manual entry, on personal laptops where there is a device at all (2024). A school without reliable internet and without machines of its own does not teach the use of the systems its pupils will later be asked to use.

Basic digital skills are handled instead as a government programme: Eswatini has a digital skills strategy and a digital skills programme focused on basic digital skills (2025). Public messaging aimed at citizens has so far been strongest on security rather than skills — the Prime Minister opened Cybersecurity Awareness Month under a "Secure Eswatini" banner in October 2025, framing cyber security as national, economic and personal security at once.

Training and skills

Eswatini's digital skills effort currently rests on a target rather than a measured base. In February 2026 the ICT Minister set a national goal of 300,000 digitally skilled citizens — coders and AI practitioners, and the ministry named the Royal Science and Technology Park, the Eswatini Innovators Association and UNDP among the partners pursuing it. It is an ambition, not a count of anyone trained.

The target is roughly a quarter of the national population (February 2026).

The established provision underneath it is modest. The government programme is aimed at basic digital skills (2025), a long way below coding and AI practice. The tertiary pipeline runs through the University of Eswatini's Department of Computer Science, which offers BSc degrees in computer science, information technology and computer science education, and MSc and postgraduate diploma programmes, with further ICT provision at the Eswatini College of Technology (2024); coding, data science and AI education are also named in a national 4IR strategy (July 2026).

Where the trained are meant to go is the harder question. The state is not itself much of an employer of them — many ministries have no ICT professional in-house at all (May 2026) — and the formal labour market absorbs a small fraction of the young people entering it each year. A state jobs portal handling jobseeker registration, vacancy search and applications is in use and reaching ordinary users (2025).

Capacity outside the universities is being added through hubs and partnerships: a government- and UNDP-backed iHub opened in Piggs Peak in 2025 with more planned across all four regions, and MTN Eswatini and the ICT Ministry opened a Content Creator Hub for the creative economy in June 2026. Youth digital skills are one strand of the government's partnership with Google (January 2025), and the Ministry of ICT has been training cross-ministry change agents ahead of the Digital Eswatini rollout.

Research institutions

Knowledge production rests on a narrow tertiary base: the University of Eswatini's Department of Computer Science carries computer science and information technology through to MSc and postgraduate diploma level, with further ICT provision at the Eswatini College of Technology (2024).

Inclusion

Access to services

Eswatini rates well on whether its public services reach everyone and badly on whether its financial ones do. Equal access to public services stood at 57.0 out of 100 in 2023, 11th of 54 African states and up 5.1 points over the decade; access to banking services stood at 14.5 out of 100, 35th of 54, having moved 0.6 points in ten years.

The headline financial-inclusion figure of 87 per cent dates from the 2018 FinScope survey and records access rather than use, as the central bank governor said plainly when launching the 2026 round (July 2026); on use, Global Findex put account ownership at 63 per cent in 2025, up from under half a decade earlier.

Almost everything the state hands out is gated on the identity card. Enrolment is compulsory from 16, free only in a three-month window and charged thereafter; the elderly grant cannot be collected without the card (2025); and when production stopped for five months, banking, employment and travel access was disrupted nationwide (February 2026). Birth registration has long been incomplete, leaving part of each cohort outside the register from the start, and public perception of how easy an identity document is to obtain was among the decade's most deteriorated measures (2023). For displaced people the gate is narrow rather than shut: refugee and non-Swazi documents are accepted by several banks and by MTN's mobile money service under simplified checks (2025).

Online, the services exist and the front door does not: tax, social protection and jobs portals are all in use and reaching ordinary users, while no single government service portal is recorded (2025), and only a small fraction of government services is online (May 2026). Outside the capital, reach is physical as much as digital — 35 post offices now take payments for government services (September 2025) — and the social registry has been piloted in one region only (2026). Digital payment systems and access points carry no accommodations for persons with disabilities, and the National Financial Inclusion Strategy 2023-2028 names them a priority but underserved segment, citing inaccessible premises and materials (2023).

Digital divides

The mobile network reaches most of Eswatini and most of Eswatini does not use it: only around 58% of people used the internet in 2024, with exclusion concentrated among rural populations, older people and people with disabilities. The headline that looks like saturation is a count of hardware rather than of people — mobile connections run well above the size of the population, but they count SIM cards rather than unique subscribers (2025). Sitting between the coverage figure and the usage figure is price: mobile data costs more than the international affordability target and fixed broadband several times more (2025).

The lines the divide follows are older than the network. Urban households had electricity at rates well above rural ones (2020); the rural economy fell further over 2014-2023 than any other sub-category of the governance index, and equality in education went backwards over the same decade. Where a digital service has reached rural areas it has usually been mobile money — MTN MoMo and e-Mali reach places banks do not, though an urban-rural gap in use persists (August 2025) — while most person-to-business payments are still made in cash (2025). Satellite capacity is now being marketed at remote schools and clinics (July 2025).

The floor beneath all of it is what people can do with a connection and what they can afford to do it for. Far more young people enter the labour market each year than the formal economy has jobs for (January 2026), against an internet-and-computers score that improved sharply over the decade and still sits below the halfway mark (2023). The state's answer to the smartphone divide is drawn but not built: the Digital Eswatini programme plans USSD-based government services so that citizens without smartphones can transact (June 2026).

Data

National statistics

Eswatini has no current strategy for developing its statistics: the international statistics partnership's country table records it as Designing at January 2026, with neither a strategy title nor a period against its name where most of its neighbours carry both, and the statute beneath it is the Statistics Act of 1967, unamended on this record. It got better at counting itself over the decade to 2023 and is still near the bottom of the continent: its Capacity of the Statistical System score rose 7.0 points over 2014-2023 to 32.3 out of 100, leaving it 47th of 54 African states.

The World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators for 2023 place the weakness precisely. Data sources is the weakest of the five pillars, in the 20-49% band, against 70-89% for both data use and data products and 50-69% for data services and data infrastructure — the state uses what it holds better than it collects it. The censuses are not the problem: a population census and an agricultural census have been run within the last ten years, and a business census within the last twenty. The survey programme is thinner: three or more labour surveys and two health surveys in the past ten years, but a single household survey — one instrument in a decade carrying everything the state knows about how households live.

Two current exercises bear on that. The Central Bank launched the FinScope Eswatini 2026 Consumer Survey on 24 July 2026, run with ESEPARC, the Central Statistical Office and FinMark Trust, adding new scope on digital financial services, fraud and climate-related risk; the headline inclusion figure it replaces dates from 2018 and measures access rather than use. In January 2026 the communications regulator awarded a tender worth about E2.8 million for a State of Communications Sector Study 2025/26.

Administrative sources carry part of the load. Civil registration covers births, deaths, marriages and divorces, with the Ministry of Home Affairs reporting operational statistics for births and deaths, and Eswatini was the second African country to launch phase two of the UN Economic Commission for Africa's civil registration mentorship programme, linking birth and death registration to the population register — against a birth register that remains incomplete. The financial management information system captures programme performance indicators, though its standardised financial classification reaches central government only. What none of it does is circulate: statistical, census and administrative data are not available for cross-government use in planning.

Open data

Eswatini publishes public records better than most of Africa and is among the worst at handing them over when asked. It scores 36.2 out of 100 for Disclosure of Public Records in 2023, 19th of 54 African states after a rise of 1.8 points over the decade, and 9.7 out of 100 for Accessibility of Public Records, 47th of 54 after a fall of 4.7 points over the same decade — one of its ten worst-scoring indicators in the whole index.

No legal route exists around that. No right to information law is in force: a bill is in draft with consultations in progress, there is no online facility for requesting records, and public records are not published online (2025). Nor is there bulk publication instead: the country has no national open data portal, putting it 191st of 195 countries on the Open Data Inventory, last in Southern Africa in the 2024 digital readiness assessment.

What is published is narrow at every point of the scale. The best categories in Open Data Watch's 2024 inventory — government finance, international trade and price statistics — score 5 out of 10, so no category reaches even the midpoint. Four score zero: digital and communications statistics, pollution, crime, and education outcomes. Among those that register something, education facilities is lowest at 1.5, energy 2, and food security, health outcomes and poverty 2.5 each; social, economic and environmental categories fare alike. The exception is the payment system, where the Central Bank publishes its clearing and switch rules, the National Payment Systems Act 2023 and the fast payments directive without registration.

Governance of data as an asset is still under construction. An established data governance body exists but sits inside another institution and has no data strategy behind it. Smart Africa is supporting a national data policy with a five-year roadmap, a first National Data Policy Workshop was held in April 2026, and a National Data Governance Policy has been validated — though its text is not published and no adoption date given. Little of how the state runs its digital government is disclosed publicly.

Use of satellite data

Satellite capability in Eswatini is connectivity, not observation. The government commissioned a Starlink satellite gateway in April 2026, inaugurated on behalf of King Mswati III by Prince Sicalo, to extend internet connectivity nationwide, the country's one ground station of consequence. It followed the July 2025 launch of Paratus Eswatini, a joint venture between the Paratus Group and Real Image Internet, as an authorised Starlink Business reseller offering managed hardware, installation and support.

The nearest thing to an institutional user of geospatial data is the Surveyor General's Department, which holds nationwide cadastral maps and survey records on a GIS platform built under a Japan International Cooperation Agency-supported digitisation project, with Swazi Nation Land still outdated and incomplete and no link to the Deeds Registry.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The American footprint in Eswatini is one memorandum of understanding with one company, and in April 2026 it split the Cabinet: Prime Minister Russell Dlamini first dismissed the Google MoU, saying Google was unaware of it and calling it a national-security threat, then acknowledged in writing that Cabinet had approved it, after the Attorney-General confirmed that Minister Savannah Maziya had consulted both Cabinet and the Attorney-General before signing. The partnership was announced in January 2025 and covers Google Workspace for public servants, artificial intelligence, digital addressing and youth digital skills. Google Cloud fronted the engagement itself, with its Africa lead on the record at the launch (January 2025).

China activities

Eswatini had no Chinese-financed, Chinese-built or Chinese-operated digital infrastructure, and no standing bilateral technology agreement with China, as at August 2026.

EU activities

European involvement in Eswatini sits in policy drafting rather than infrastructure, and runs through German development co-operation. Support for the National Data Governance Policy comes through the Team Europe Data Governance in Africa Initiative, with GIZ and the African Union (July 2026). GIZ also supplies the technical and financial backing behind the Smart Africa-drafted health-data guidelines now in validation (July 2026).

Gulf/UAE activities

Gulf involvement in Eswatini is at the discussion stage. ICT Minister Savannah Maziya met Global South Utilities, an Abu Dhabi clean-energy and infrastructure firm, at the World Government Summit in Dubai in February 2026 to discuss dedicated and sustainable power for the National Data Centre and future digital infrastructure; no agreement was signed at that meeting, and no capacity, price or timetable was stated. A partnership with the United Arab Emirates on AI-enabled policing was at the planning stage in 2025 as part of the response to cybercrime.

India activities

India's presence is a single credit line: India's Export-Import Bank signed a soft loan of about US$10 million with the Government of Eswatini in 2021 to fund a disaster recovery site for the national data centre under Phase 2 of the Royal Science and Technology Park, intended to give government IT systems and national data assets a secondary facility for business continuity.

India's Export-Import Bank is the only bilateral lender among the external financing commitments recorded for Eswatini's digital estate (August 2026).

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	**2026-09-01**
CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/SWZ/SWZ-status.html
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/SWZ/SWZ-status-2026-09-01.pdf
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